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Interactive way-finder

Abstract

An interactive way-finder system includes an interactive way-finder device having device communications circuitry and a display that displays one or more hands pointing in the direction of a destination based on proximity information received from communications circuitry of a destination. The destination is represented on the display as a displayed destination and may be an attraction, a restaurant, an amusement park exit, restrooms, or the like. The destination may be selected based on user input, on location of the interactive way-finder system in the amusement park, or based on a user profile. The communication between the interactive way-finder device and the destination may enable special effects at the destination, onboard effects on the interactive way-finder device, or both. The interactive way-finder device may be capable of operating in several different modes.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

(1) This section is intended to introduce the reader to various aspects of art that may be related to various aspects of the present techniques, which are described and/or claimed below. This

discussion is believed to be helpful in providing the reader with background information to facilitate a better understanding of the various aspects of the present disclosure. Accordingly, it should be understood that these statements are to be read in this light, and not as admissions of prior art.

(2) Amusement parks or similar entertainment facilities may have a multitude of attractions that are spread out over a large geographical area. Guests in amusement parks or similar entertainment facilities may need assistance in locating various attractions (e.g., rides and interactive features). However, guests may not know or be able to easily discern the locations of each of these attractions.

SUMMARY

(3) Certain embodiments commensurate in scope with the originally claimed subject matter are summarized below. These embodiments are not intended to limit the scope of the disclosure, but rather these embodiments are intended only to provide a brief summary of certain disclosed embodiments. Indeed, the present disclosure may encompass a variety of forms that may be similar to or different from the embodiments set forth below.

(4) In an embodiment, an interactive way-finder system is disclosed. The interactive way-finder system includes a destination that has an emitter and an interactive way-finder device. The interactive way-finder device includes a housing, a display coupled to the housing that includes a hand, and device communications circuitry disposed within the housing. The device communications circuitry is configured to receive proximity information from the emitter. The interactive way-finder device also includes a controller configured to control the display to change a characteristic of the hand based on the proximity information.

(5) In another embodiment, an interactive way-finder device is disclosed. The interactive way-finder device includes a housing, a display coupled to the housing that includes a hand, memory disposed in the housing, an inertial measurement unit sensor disposed in the housing, and device communications circuitry disposed in the housing. The device communications circuitry is configured to receive proximity information from a plurality of emitters in a wireless network and store the proximity information in the memory. The interactive way-finder device also includes a controller configured to change a position of the hand based on inertial data from the inertial measurement unit sensor, control the display based at least in part on the proximity information, and cause the display to present a displayed destination.

(6) In another embodiment, a method of way finding with an interactive way-finder device is disclosed. The method includes receiving a first signal comprising first proximity information for an attraction via wireless communications circuitry, providing instructions to cause a display of an interactive way-finder device to display information related to the attraction based on the first proximity information, receiving a second signal comprising second proximity information for the attraction via the wireless communications circuitry, and providing updated instructions to cause the display of the interactive way-finder device to display updated information related to the attraction based on the second proximity information.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) These and other features, aspects, and advantages of the present disclosure will become better understood when the following detailed description is read with reference to the accompanying drawings in which like characters represent like parts throughout the drawings, wherein:

(2) FIG. 1 is a schematic view of an amusement park including attractions and an interactive way-finder system, in accordance with present embodiments;

(3) FIG. 2 is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-

finder system, in accordance with present embodiments;

(4) FIG. 3 is a block diagram of an interactive way-finder device within an interactive way-finder system, in accordance with present embodiments;

(5) FIG. 4A is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in a “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is at a distance, d1, from an interactive station, in accordance with present embodiments;

(6) FIG. 4B is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in a “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is at a distance, d2, from the interactive station, in accordance with present embodiments;

(7) FIG. 4C is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is at a distance, d3, from the interactive station, in accordance with present embodiments;

(8) FIG. 5A is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is pointing to a destination “park exit” based on the location of the interactive way-finder device, in accordance with present embodiments;

(9) FIG. 5B is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is pointing to a destination “Volcano Flow” based on the location of the interactive way-finder device, for example based on the location of the interactive way-finder device in the amusement park, in accordance with present embodiments;

(10) FIG. 5C is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, where the interactive way-finder device is pointing to a destination “Park” based on the location of the interactive way-finder device, for example, based on the location of the interactive way-finder device outside the amusement park, in accordance with present embodiments;

(11) FIG. 6A is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “classic compass” mode, where the destination is “Volcano Flow,” in accordance with present embodiments;

(12) FIG. 6B is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “classic compass” mode, where the destination is “magnetic north,” in accordance with present embodiments;

(13) FIG. 7 is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system, in accordance with present embodiments;

(14) FIG. 8 is a flow diagram illustrating a method of way-finding using an interactive way-finder device, in accordance with present embodiments; and

(15) FIG. 9 is a schematic illustration of an interactive way-finder device in an interactive way-finder system, in accordance with present embodiments.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(16) One or more specific embodiments of the present disclosure will be described below. In an effort to provide a concise description of these embodiments, all features of an actual implementation may not be described in the specification. It should be appreciated that in the development of any such actual implementation, as in any engineering or design project, numerous implementation-specific decisions must be made to achieve the developers' specific goals, such as compliance with system-related and business-related constraints, which may vary from one implementation to another. Moreover, it should be appreciated that such a development effort might be complex and time consuming, but would nevertheless be a routine undertaking of design, fabrication, and manufacture for those of ordinary skill having the benefit of this disclosure. Further, to the extent that certain terms such as parallel, perpendicular, and so forth are used herein, it should be understood that these terms allow for certain deviations from a strict mathematical

definition, for example to allow for deviations associated with manufacturing imperfections and associated tolerances.

(17) When introducing elements of various embodiments of the present disclosure, the articles “a,” “an,” and “the” are intended to mean that there are one or more of the elements. The terms “comprising,” “including,” and “having” are intended to be inclusive and mean that there may be additional elements other than the listed elements. Additionally, it should be understood that references to “one embodiment” or “an embodiment” of the present disclosure are not intended to be interpreted as excluding the existence of additional embodiments that also incorporate the recited features.

(18) It is now recognized that amusement park guests or guests of similar facilities (e.g., malls, concert venues, and campuses) may benefit from interactive devices that provide geographical guidance and interactive experiences. In the present disclosure, reference is frequently made to use of present embodiments in an amusement park; however, it should be understood that an amusement park is only one example of many different venues in which present embodiments may be employed. Indeed, it is now recognized that guests of various venues may desire or even require assistance navigating to points of interest. Further, it is now recognized that such guests may seek opportunities for interactive experiences within the venues. Accordingly, present embodiments are directed to an interactive way-finder device and system that, in addition to providing navigational guidance, interacts with attractions when within a certain distance, causing a reaction on the interactive way-finder device, a reaction on the attraction, or both. As an example, an interactive way-finder device in accordance with the present disclosure may direct guests to various attractions, including the nearest interactive feature, in an amusement park and provide interactive options or experiences directly from the interactive way-finder device along the way.

(19) FIG. 1 is a schematic illustration of an amusement park **10** that incorporates an interactive way-finder system **12**. The system **12** may include interactive way-finder devices **100** associated with guests **16**. An interactive way-finder device **100** may operate in different modes to assist a guest **16** with finding destinations **120**. The types of destinations **120** may depend on the mode of the interactive way-finder device **100**. For example, in one mode, the destination **120** may be the nearest ride **54** or a premier ride associated with the region of the amusement park **10** in which the guest **16** is located. In another mode, the destination **120** may be the nearest interactive feature **40**, for example a gesture interactive station such as a puppet station **40**, or an interactive feature **42** that interacts with the interactive way-finder device **100** itself. The interactive features **40**, **42** may be configured to only interact with guests that have an interactive way-finder device **100**, which may provide an incentive for a guest to purchase an interactive way-finder device **100**. In yet another mode, the destination **120** may be the park exit **80**, the nearest restaurant **50**, or the nearest restroom facilities **56**. In a “gaming” mode, the destination **120** may be associated with a treasure hunt or other type of game.

(20) The mode of the interactive way-finder device **100** may be selected by the guest **16** using a mode switch **114** (as shown in FIG. 2), or may be automatically selected based on the guest's location in the amusement park **10** or based on a user profile, or may be selected based on a combination of automatically detected information and guest input (e.g., via the mode switch **114**).

(21) The interactive way-finder device **100** may communicate wirelessly with sensors **60** at various destinations **120** in the amusement park **10** to determine the relative distance from the interactive way-finder device **100** to the destination **120** and update a display **105** (as shown in FIG. 2) on the interactive way-finder device **100** accordingly. In an embodiment, the sensors **60** are associated with various destinations **120** as described above, which could include entrance gates for areas of the amusement park **10**, attraction entrances, interactive features **40**, **42**, multiplayer game sites **64**, the park exit **80**, a restaurant **50**, or restroom facilities **56**. Further, the interactive way-finder device **100** may activate a reaction in an interactive feature or other attraction (e.g., spinning of clock hands, spinning of windmill arms, water sprays, bubbles, confetti) at various locations in the

amusement park **10**. Such interactions and activations may be based on one or more of detection of the interactive way-finder device **100** within a threshold distance of the attraction, input provided via the interactive way-finder device **100**, actions performed on an interface of an interactive feature via the interactive way-finder device **100** or in its presence, detected movement (e.g., gestures) of an individual holding the interactive way-finder device **100**, and/or the like. In one example, the presence of the interactive way-finder device **100** within a proximity to a destination **120**, such as an interactive feature **42**, activates a local special effect, e.g., based on the proximity of the interactive way-finder device **100** wirelessly communicated to the sensor **60**. In another embodiment, the proximity of the interactive way-finder device **100** to an interactive feature **40** may activate onboard effects of the interactive way-finder device **100**, such as a change in the appearance of the display of the interactive way-finder device **100**, or a haptic effect, such as a vibration. In another embodiment, the proximity of the interactive way-finder device **100** to an interactive feature **40** may activate a response in the interactive feature **40**, and/or activate a local special effect, and/or activate onboard effects of the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(22) The interactive way-finder system **12** may include a central controller **70**, which may be implemented as a distributed server or computer system **72**. The central controller **70** may communicate with the interactive way-finder devices **100** and/or the sensors **60** via a network, such as a wireless network **76**, and may permit operator input via an operator interface **78**. Thus, the central controller **70** may monitor operation of the interactive way-finder devices **100** throughout an area, which may facilitate data tracking and system maintenance. For example, the central controller **70** may be configured to identify malfunctions in the interactive way-finder devices **100**, the sensors **60**, the interactive features **42**, and so forth.

(23) FIG. 2 is a schematic illustration of an embodiment of an interactive way-finder device **100**. In the illustrated embodiment, the interactive way-finder device **100** includes a housing **102**, a display **105** including a face **104**, hands **106**, **108**, **110**. In the illustrated embodiment, the interactive way-finder device **100** also includes a mode switch **114**. The hands **106**, **108**, **110** are designed to move in a radial direction, where the ends of the hands farthest away from the center of the face **104** move in a manner similar to that of hands on a clock (but not necessarily in a single direction in correlation with time). While the housing **102** is illustrated as a rectangle, the housing **102** may take any shape. In an embodiment, the display **105**, including the face **104**, is coupled to the housing **102**, and may be a physical display, for example, as on a clock or a compass. In another embodiment, the display **105**, including the face **104**, is coupled to the housing **102**, and may be an electronic display, such as an LCD (liquid crystal display), OLED (organic light-emitting diodes) display, or other electronic display. In an embodiment, the hands **106**, **108**, and **110** may be physical objects, for example, physical hands as on a clock or a compass. In another embodiment, the hands **106**, **108**, and **110** may be electronic hands, such as an LCD display, OLED display, or other electronic display. The display **105** may include a face **104** that also may include one or more displayed destinations **112**. The displayed destination **112** is representative of the destination **120** and may be entrance gates for areas of the amusement park **10**, attraction entrances, interactive features **40**, **42**, multiplayer game sites **64**, the park exit **80**, a restaurant **50**, restroom facilities **56**, or other destination. In an embodiment, the displayed destination **112** may change depending on the mode of operation of the interactive way-finder device **100**, as described in more detail below.

(24) FIG. 3 is a block diagram of one embodiment of the interactive way-finder system **12** including the interactive way-finder device **100** and a destination **120** having a sensor **60**. Once engaged, the interactive way-finder device **100** may activate certain functions, as described in more detail below, under control of a processor **121** of a controller **118** and stored in a memory **122**.

(25) The processor **121** may include one or more processing devices, and the memory **122** may include one or more tangible, non-transitory, machine-readable media. By way of example, such machine-readable media can include RAM, ROM, EPROM, EEPROM, magnetic storage devices, or any other medium which can be used to carry or store desired program code in the form of

machine-executable instructions or data structures and which can be accessed by the processor or by other processor-based devices.

(26) The interactive way-finder device **100** may also include an inertial measurement unit (IMU) sensor **93**. The IMU sensor may include gyroscopes to measure and report angular rate, accelerometers to measure and report specific force and/or magnetometers to measure the magnetic field surrounding the interactive way-finder device **100**. In an embodiment, a signal from the IMU sensor **93** drives an orientation of the display **105**. A signal from an accelerometer of the IMU sensor **93** may be used to identify the correct orientation for the display **105** depending on how the interactive way-finder device **100** is being held. In addition, the signal from the IMU sensor **93** may allow the hand **110** (shown in FIG. 2) to point to “magnetic north” and also provide input to adjust the positions of the hands **106** and **108** (shown in FIG. 2) when the interactive way-finder device **100** is in “hot-and-cold” mode as described below, based on the direction of travel as determined by the IMU sensor **93**. “Magnetic north” means the direction in which the north end of a compass needle or other freely suspended magnet will point in response to the earth's magnetic field.

(27) The interactive way-finder device **100** may also include one or more sensors **130**, such as a pressure sensor or an ambient light sensor (as input to adjust display brightness). These sensors **130** may be utilized separately or in conjunction with the IMU sensor **93** to facilitate certain operations. For example, changes in pressure or lighting may be used separately or in conjunction with location sensing to identify where the interactive way-finder device **100** is located. For example, changes in pressure and/or lighting may indicate or confirm that the interactive way-finder device **100** has moved into a climate-controlled building and/or that the interactive way-finder device **100** is proximate an interactive feature **40**, **42** with a certain type of lighting.

(28) The interactive way-finder device **100** may have different levels of power supplied from a power source **124** that may correspond to different power modes: standby mode, active mode, and OFF. For example, the power source **124** may supply low power to the interactive way-finder device **100** while in standby mode. While in standby mode, for example, the power source **124** may supply enough power to the interactive way-finder device so that the IMU sensor **93** may detect motion of the interactive way-finder device **100**, but not enough power to fully activate the display **105**, face **104**, and other features. Movement of the interactive way-finder device **100** as detected by the IMU sensor **93** may switch the power source **124** from standby mode (low power) to active mode (full power), where the display **105** (including but not limited to the hands **106**, **108**, and **110**), the face **104** (which may be an e-ink or other low power display, or may be an OLED display), and other features described herein are activated. In addition, low power and/or high power may be activated from the power source **124** of the interactive way-finder device **100** by a power switch being turned to “standby/ON” and/or “active/ON” (not pictured). The power may be switched from active mode to standby mode after a specific time period has elapsed during which the interactive way-finder device **100** has not been moved, as determined by the IMU sensor **93**. The power may be deactivated from the power source **124** of the interactive way-finder device **100**, for example, by a power switch being turned to “OFF” (not pictured).

(29) In certain embodiments, the interactive way-finder device **100** may also include additional onboard features, such as the motor **92**. The motor **92** may be powered by the power source **124**. The motor **92** may be used to adjust the position of the hands **106**, **108**, **110** in an embodiment where the hands **106**, **108**, and **110** are mechanical (not graphics or elements of a displayed image). The motor **92** may alternatively or additionally be used in relation to onboard effects **128**, as described below. The motor **92** may be an induction motor, a stepper motor, or the like.

(30) The interactive way-finder device **100**, in an embodiment, may also include onboard effects **128**, such as one or more light emitting diodes (LEDs), one or more haptic functions (for example a vibration function, a force function, or the like), a sound, a change in the display **105** such as a change in the colors of the display **105**, spinning hands **106**, **108**, **110**, or other onboard effects, that are activated in conjunction with interactive events, as described in more detail below. These

onboard effects **128** may also be powered by the motor **92** or more generally by the power source **124**. The interactive way-finder device **100** may include other input/output devices **129** for user inputs, such as additional buttons, soft keys, notification devices, audio input/output devices, etc. (31) The interactive way-finder device **100** includes device communications circuitry **123**, such as transceivers, antennas, transmitters, receivers, radio transceiver circuits, and signal processing hardware and/or software (e.g., hardware or software filters, analog/digital converters, multiplexers amplifiers), or a combination thereof, that may be powered by the power source **124** and configured to communicate over wireless communication paths via Infrared wireless communication, radio frequency transmission, Bluetooth, Wi-Fi, near-field communication (NFC), ultra wideband (UWB), etc.

(32) In some embodiments, the interactive way-finder device **100** may form a communication connection with the sensor **60** on the destination **120** using a wireless network **76**, for example, wireless communication paths via IR wireless communication, radio frequency transmission, Bluetooth, Wi-Fi, ultra wideband (UWB), etc. That is, the destination **120** may be equipped with devices including the sensor **60** that enable the communication between the interactive way-finder device **100** and the sensor **60** on the destination **120**. For example, the sensor **60** on the destination **120** may include destination communications circuitry **148**, such as a transmitter and a receiver.

(33) As provided herein, the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** may communicate with the destination communications circuitry **148** by sending a signal that is received by the sensor **60** of the destination **120**. The destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60** may communicate proximity information back to the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** via the destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60**. The proximity information may include information regarding the distance from and orientation of the sensor **60** in relation to the location of the interactive way-finder device **100**. The controller **118** of the interactive way-finder device **100** receives the proximity information and may trigger activity based on the received proximity information, including updating the positions of the hands **106**, **108**, **110**, altering the appearance of the face **104**, or activating onboard effects **128** of the interactive way-finder device **100**. Updating the positions of the hands **106**, **108**, **110** may be accomplished based on the communication between the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** and the destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60** on the destination **120** in conjunction with input from the IMU sensor **93**, as discussed above.

(34) FIGS. 4A, 4B, and 4C are each schematic illustrations of an embodiment of an interactive way-finder device **100** in a specific mode, which may be described as “hot-and-cold.” As used herein, the term “hot-and-cold” is not intended to reflect actual temperatures but instead is used in the context of a game where as a person gets closer to a desired destination, they are deemed to be getting “hotter” and as a person gets farther away from a desired destination, they are deemed to be getting “colder.” As illustrated in FIG. 4A, the display **105** of the interactive way-finder device **100** includes a face **104** and has a displayed destination **112** representative of an interactive station **40** such as “puppet station.” The ends of the hands **106** and **108** on the face **104** are on either side of the displayed destination **112** on the face **104**. In the example illustrated in FIGS. 4A, 4B, and 4C, the destination **120** is the puppet station **40** and includes sensor **60**. In the embodiment illustrated in FIG. 4A, the sensor **60** receives a signal **149** from the device communications circuitry **123** on the interactive way-finder device **100**. The destination communications circuitry **148** within the sensor **60** responds with a signal **150** that is received by the device communications circuitry **123** on the interactive way-finder device **100**. In the embodiment illustrated in FIG. 4B, the sensor **60** on the destination **120** may be an emitter that emits a signal **151** (for example, a signal that is not in response to receiving a signal from the interactive way-finder device **100**) that is received by the device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100**, which results in the interactive way-finder device **100** to adjust the position of one or more of the hands **106**, **108**, **110**,

as described below.

(35) As illustrated in FIGS. 4A, 4B, and 4C, the position of the hands **106** and **108** move depending on whether the interactive way-finder device **100** is getting closer to the puppet station **40** or farther away from the puppet station **40**. Generally, as the interactive way-finder device **100** gets closer to the puppet station **40** (as determined through the wireless interaction of the destination communications circuitry **148** on the sensor **60** of the puppet station **40** and the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100**), the hands **106** and **108** get closer together in the radial direction, one on each side of the displayed destination **112**, illustrated in FIGS. 4A, 4B, and 4C as “puppet station”. That is, the ends of the hands **106** and **108** get closer together as the guest holding the interactive way-finder device **100** is getting “hotter”. As the interactive way-finder device **100** gets farther away from the puppet station **40** (as determined through the wireless interaction of the destination communications circuitry **148** on the sensor **60** of the puppet station **40** and the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100**), the hands **106** and **108** get farther apart in the radial direction. That is the ends of the hands **106** and **108** get farther apart as the guest holding the interactive way-finder device **100** is getting “colder”. For example, in FIG. 4A, the interactive way-finder device **100** is at a distance, **d1**, from the puppet station **40**. As shown in FIG. 4A, ends of the hands on the interactive way-finder device **100** are on either side of the displayed destination **112** “puppet station” on the face **104**. As shown in FIG. 4B, the interactive way-finder device **100** is at a distance, **d2**, from the puppet station **40**. The distance **d2** is larger than the distance **d1** in FIG. 4A. As a result, the ends of the hands **106** and **108** are farther apart on the face **104** of the interactive way-finder device **100** in FIG. 4B than in FIG. 4A. As shown in FIG. 4C, the interactive way-finder device **100** is at a distance, **d3**, from the puppet station **40**. The distance **d3** is smaller than **d1** or **d2**. As shown in FIG. 4C, the ends of the hands on the interactive way-finder device **100** are converging on the displayed destination **112** of “puppet station” on the face **104**.

(36) When operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, the display **105**, or a portion of the display **105** such as the face **104**, may change colors. For example, coloring of the display **105** (e.g., imagery or a background of the display **105**) may shift to a reddish hue, as the interactive way-finder device **100** gets closer to the destination **120** and is thus getting “hotter.” When the interactive way-finder device **100** gets farther away from the destination **120**, the display **105**, or a portion of the display **105**, such as the face **104**, may shift to a greenish or bluish hue to signal to the guest that they are getting “colder.” In an embodiment, the colors of hands **106** and **108** may also change depending on whether the interactive way-finder device **100** is getting closer to the destination **120** or farther away from the destination **120**.

(37) In an embodiment, the interactive way-finder device **100** may operate in this “hot-and-cold” mode with the positions of the hands **106** and **108** moving with respect to the distance between the interactive way-finder device **100** and the destination **120**. The destination **120** in such an embodiment may be selected by the interactive way-finder device **100** based on the location of the interactive way-finder device **100** in the amusement park **10**. It should be understood that the position of the displayed destination **112** of “puppet station” on the display **105** may change based on the orientation of the interactive way-finder device **100**. For example, if the interactive way-finder device is turned, the position of the displayed destination **112** on the display **105** will move relative to the way-finder device to reflect the appropriate position and direction of the puppet station **40**.

(38) FIGS. 5A, 5B, and 5C are each schematic illustrations of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “hot-and-cold” mode, in which the interactive way-finder device is pointing to different destinations **120** as selected by the interactive way-finder device **100**. The mode in which the interactive way-finder device **100** selects the destination **120** is referred to herein as “automatic mode.” For example, if the interactive way-finder device **100** is within a certain distance from the exit of the amusement park, when in “automatic mode,” the

interactive way-finder device **100**, specifically the controller **118** within the interactive way-finder device **100**, automatically selects the destination **120** as, for example, the park exit **80**, and causes the display **105** to present the displayed destination **112** on the face **104** of the interactive way-finder device **100**. The displayed destination **112** may be the park exit **80**, as shown in FIG. 5A. As another example, if the interactive way-finder device **100** is within a certain distance from a premier attraction, when in “automatic mode,” the interactive way-finder device **100**, specifically the controller **118** within the interactive way-finder device, automatically selects the destination **120** as the premiere attraction and causes the display **105** to present the displayed destination **112** as the selected destination **120** (e.g., present the title of the attraction, such as Volcano Flow, on display **105**), as shown in FIG. 5B. As another example, when in “automatic mode,” if the interactive way-finder device **100** is outside of the amusement park, the interactive way-finder device **100**, specifically the controller **118** within the interactive way-finder device **100**, automatically selects the destination **120** as, for example, the amusement park itself (e.g., the amusement park entrance) and causes the display **105** to present the displayed destination **112** as the amusement park, as shown in FIG. 5C.

(39) The logic for assessing the selection of the destination **120** based on the location of the interactive way-finder device **100** in the amusement park **10** may be resident on the controller **118** or may be resident on a central controller **70** in wireless communication with the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(40) In “automatic mode,” in addition to the location of the interactive way-finder device **100**, the logic for assessing the selection of the destination **120** may also take into account the history of the guest as informed by a user profile, associated with a guest or user and associated with user information. User information stored in the user or guest profile may include information such as how many times the guest has been at a particular destination **120** before, how many time the guest has been to the amusement park **10** before, and the like. The interactive way-finder device **100** may have access to the user profile, and the user profile may inform the selection of the destination **120** by the interactive way-finder device **100** when in “automatic mode.” For example, if a guest has already experienced a premier ride on a particular day or within a particular number of days, the logic for assessing selection of the destination **120** may select the next-closest or next-most-popular premier ride as the destination **120**. In addition, the guest may provide a list of preferred premier rides that the logic may use as a selection list.

(41) In another embodiment, the guest **16** may select the type of destination **120** via the mode switch **114**. The mode in which the guest **16** selects the destination **120** based on the guest's preferences is referred to herein as “guest selection mode.” For example, a guest may select “interactive station” using the mode switch **114**, in which case the destination **120** is the interactive station, for example a gesture interactive station such as a puppet station **40**, closest to the interactive way-finder device **100**, and the displayed destination **112** on the face **104** of the interactive way-finder device **100** is the puppet station. As another example, a guest may select “rides” using the mode switch **114**, in which case the destination **120** is the nearest ride to the interactive way-finder device **100** and the displayed destination **112** on the display **105** of the interactive way-finder device **100** is the nearest ride. As another example, a guest may select “all” using the mode switch **114**, in which case the destination **120** is the nearest destination **120** having a sensor **60**—whether it be a gesture interactive station, a premier attraction, or the park exit, for example—to the interactive way-finder device **100**. The displayed destination **112** on the display **105** of the interactive way-finder device **100** updates accordingly. The display **105**, or portions of the display **105** such as the face **104**, may change colors or otherwise change appearance depending on the mode in which the interactive way-finder device **100** is operating. The logic for enabling the guest **16** to select the destination **120** may be resident on the controller **118** or may be resident on a central controller **70** in wireless communication with the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(42) In another embodiment, the guest **16** may choose for the interactive way-finder device **100** to

operate in a “game mode,” in which the destination **120** is related to a game, for example a treasure hunt, a scavenger hunt, a quest, a monster hunt, or other game related to finding certain destinations. In “game mode,” the display **105**, the face **104**, and/or the hands **106**, **108**, **110** of the interactive way-finder device **100** may change in appearance to match the theme of the game. For example, if the guest selects “treasure hunt”, the display **105** and the face **104** may appear as a treasure map and the hands **106**, **108**, and **110** may appear in an old-fashioned style. As another example, if the guest **16** selects “monster hunt,” the display **105** and the face **104** may appear as a monster and the hands **106**, **108**, and **110** may appear as stylized arrows.

(43) FIGS. **6A** and **6B** are each schematic illustrations of an interactive way-finder device of an interactive way-finder system operating in “classic compass” mode, in which the hand **110** points in the direction to the destination **120**, as illustrated in FIGS. **6A** and **6B**. The destination **120** may be a specific attraction, for example a premier attraction, as shown in FIG. **6A**. In the alternative, the destination **120** may be magnetic north, as in a typical compass, as shown in FIG. **6B**. In the alternative, the destination **120** may be any of those described with respect to “hot-and-cold” mode. Destinations **120** in “classic compass” mode may be chosen automatically by the interactive way-finder device **100**, as in “automatic mode” as described above, or may be chosen by the guest **16**, as described above in “guest-selection” mode.

(44) In an embodiment, the interactive way-finder device **100** may operate in “hot-and-cold” mode and “classic compass” mode at the same time, and thus use the hand **110** as a “classic compass” and the hands **106** and **108** as “hot-and-cold” indicators, as shown, for example, in FIG. **4**. For example, the interactive way-finder device **100** may operate in “classic compass” mode in which the hand **110** points directly to the displayed destination **112**, where displayed destination **112** corresponds to a destination **120**—while the interactive way-finder device **100** also operates in “hot-and-cold” mode in which the hands **106** and **108** are on either side of the displayed destination **112** and get closer together as the interactive way-finder device **100** gets closer to the destination **120**.

(45) The various modes in which the interactive way-finder device **100** may operate may be summarized as follows, with the understanding that there may be additional modes or sub-modes that fall within the scope of the present disclosure. It is to be understood that the interactive way-finder device **100** may operate in one or more of the below modes or sub-modes at any given time.

(46) In “hot-and-cold” mode, the destinations **120** may be selected automatically by the interactive way-finder device **100** (“automatic mode”) or may be selected by the guest (“guest selection mode”). In addition, the destinations **120** may be selected from a wide variety of categories including but not limited to an attraction (for example, the closest ride, the most popular attraction within a proximity, the closest interactive feature, which may include an interactive feature **42** that interacts with the interactive way-finder device **100** and/or another device, such as a wristband or other object), a game (for example, in which the destination **120** is associated with a game such as a treasure hunt), amenities (for example, the nearest restaurant **50**, restroom facilities **56**, park exit **80**, and the like), or all destinations (for example, multiple destinations, each with a corresponding displayed destination **112** on the face **104**, with designated hands indicating the direction of a particular destination **120**).

(47) Similarly, in “classic compass” mode, the destinations **120** may be selected automatically by the interactive way-finder device **100** (“automatic mode”) or may be selected by the guest (“guest selection mode”). In addition, the destinations **120** may be selected from a wide variety of categories including but not limited to magnetic north, an attraction (for example, the closest ride, the most popular attraction within a proximity, the closest interactive feature **40**, which may include an interactive feature that interacts with the interactive way-finder device **100** and/or another device, such as a wristband or other object), a game (for example, in which the destination **120** is associated with a game such as a treasure hunt), amenities (for example, the nearest restaurant **50**, restroom facilities **56**, park exit **80**, and the like), or all destinations (for example, multiple

destinations, each with a corresponding displayed destination **112** on the face **104**, with designated hands indicating the direction of a particular destination **120**).

(48) FIG. **7** is a schematic illustration of another embodiment of the present disclosure wherein an interactive way-finder device **200** may have more than one face in the housing **202**. While the embodiment illustrated in FIG. **7** has two faces, **204** and **205**, it is to be understood that an embodiment could have more than two faces. Multiple faces in the same housing **202** would allow the interactive way-finder device **200** to operate in a separate mode on each respective face, while each face is displayed to the guest. For example, face **204** may operate in “classic compass” mode with hand **210** pointing to “north,” while face **205** operates in “hot-and-cold” mode with hands **206** and **208** to direct the guest toward a destination **120** such as a puppet station **40**. Additional faces in the housing **202** could operate, for example, in “hot-and-cold” mode to direct the guest toward a destination **120** such as premier attraction **54** or to the park exit **80**. Switching among modes may be accomplished by using a mode switch, **214**.

(49) The communication may include wireless communication protocols, for example UWB, IR, radio frequency transmission, that enable communication between electronic devices over a distance, such as between 4 meters (m) and 20 m. The communication may be indicative of the interactive way-finder device **100** being within a certain proximity of the sensor **60** on the destination **120**. The communication may result in the interactive way-finder device adjusting the position of one or more of the hands **106**, **108**, **110** on the interactive way-finder device **100**, as described above. As described above, in another embodiment, the sensor **60** on the destination **120** may be an emitter that emits a signal received by the device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100**, which results in the interactive way-finder device **100** to adjust the position of one or more of the hands **106**, **108**, **110**.

(50) FIG. **8** is a flow diagram illustrating one embodiment of a process **300** for operating the interactive way-finder device **100**, in accordance with present techniques. It is to be understood that the steps discussed herein are merely exemplary, and certain steps may be omitted or added, and the steps may be performed in a different order. In one embodiment, the steps of the process **300** may be executed by the interactive way-finder device **100** and other components of the system **12**, such as a destination **120** having destination communications circuitry **148**.

(51) The process **300** includes a step of sending a signal via wireless communications circuitry comprising first proximity information (block **152**). The signal may be sent by the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** and may include proximity information indicative of the location of the interactive way-finder device **100**. This signal is received by the destination communications circuitry **148** on a sensor **60** on a destination **120**, which sends a signal in response. The process **300** also includes a step of receiving a second signal (i.e., the response signal) that comprises second proximity information (block **154**). The second proximity information is indicative of the relative location of the destination communications circuitry **148** on the sensor **60** on the destination **120** compared to the location of the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100**. The process **300** also includes the step of providing instructions to cause the display **105** of the interactive way-finder device **100** to display information based on the second proximity information (block **156**).

Displaying information based on the second proximity information may include, for example, moving the hands **106** and **108** on the display **105** on either side of the displayed destination **112**, which corresponds with the destination **120**, when the interactive way-finder device **100** is in “hot-and-cold” mode. When in “classic compass” mode, displaying information based on the second proximity information may include, for example, moving the hand **110** to point directly at the displayed destination **112**, which corresponds with the destination **120**. The interactive way-finder device **100** then sends a third signal via wireless communications circuitry comprising third proximity information (block **158**). This third signal is received by destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60** on the destination **120**, which sends a fourth signal in response. This

fourth signal comprises fourth proximity information and is received by the device communications circuitry **123** on the interactive way-finder device **100** (block **160**). Updated instructions are provided to cause the display **105** of the interactive way-finder device **100** to display updated information based on the fourth proximity information (block **162**). As explained above, displaying information based on the fourth proximity information may include, for example, moving the hands **106** and **108** on the display **105** on either side of the displayed destination **112**, which corresponds with the destination **120**, when the interactive way-finder device **100** is in “hot-and-cold” mode. When in “classic compass” mode, displaying information based on the second proximity information may include, for example, moving the hand **110** to point directly at the displayed destination **112**, which corresponds with the destination **120**. In this way, the display **105** is updated as the location of the interactive way-finder device **100** changes relative to the location of the destination **120** (and more specifically, the location of the destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60** on the destination **120**).

(52) The mode in which the interactive way-finder device **100** operates may be switched by the guest **16**. For example, the interactive way-finder device **100** may start up in “automatic” mode where destinations **120** are selected based on location of interactive way-finder device **100** in the amusement park **10** or informed by the guest's user profile, as described above. When the interactive way-finder device **100** is in a particular region of the amusement park **10**, the displayed destinations **112** may be a premier attraction in that region, an interactive feature **40** in that region, and a restaurant **50** in that region. If the guest **16** is more interested in a specific category of destinations, however, the guest **16** may switch to “guest selection” mode, using the mode switch **114**, and the destinations **120** may be selected by the guest **16**, for example based on a category of destinations, like all the restaurants in the amusement park, or all the premier attractions in the amusement park. This mode switching is accomplished using the mode switch **114** on the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(53) The interactive way-finder system **12** may be employed to add a layer of entertainment to other entertainment features. In another embodiment, the communication between the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** and the destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60** on the destination **120** may result in a reaction at the destination **120** including special effects, such as producing bubbles, water sprays, and/or confetti. In another embodiment, the communication may result in a reaction of the interactive way-finder device **100**, for example activating onboard effects of the interactive way-finder device **100**. In another embodiment, the communication may result in a reaction of both special effects at the destination **120** and a reaction of the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(54) For example, as illustrated in FIG. **9**, the system **12** may be employed in conjunction with interactive features in the amusement park to add to guest enjoyment and immersion in the environment. Specifically, FIG. **9** illustrates a guest **16** in a portion of the amusement park utilizing the system **12** to actuate activation of an interactive feature **42**, illustrated as a windmill, integrated in the environment. In this example, the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** transmits a signal **406** from the interactive way-finder device **100**. The signal **406** is received by the destination communications circuitry **148** of the sensor **60**, and circuitry within sensor **60** causes a reaction in the interactive feature **42** that is observable by the guest **16**, for example, the blades of the windmill to spin rapidly. The destination communications circuitry **148** within sensor **60** may also produce a response signal **406** that is received by the device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100**, which causes the controller **118** to activate the onboard effects **128** of the interactive way-finder device **100**. It should be understood that the reaction triggered by the proximity of the interactive way-finder device **100** and the destination **120** may be one-way (i.e., only one of the interactive way-finder device **100** or the destination **120** has a reaction) or two-way (i.e., both the interactive way-finder device **100** and the destination **120** have a reaction). As described above, the sensor **60** on the destination **120** may

be an emitter that emits a signal (for example, a signal that is not in response to receiving a signal from the interactive way-finder device **100**) that is received by the device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100**, which causes the controller **118** to activate onboard effects **128** of the interactive way-finder device **100**.

(55) As described above, the interactive way-finder device **100** may be associated with a guest or user profile associated with user information. User information stored in the guest profile may include information such as how many times the guest **16** has been at a particular destination **120** before, how many time the guest **16** has been to the amusement park **10** before, and the like. The reaction in the destination **120** may vary depending on the user information in the guest profile of the interactive way-finder device **100**. For example, if the user information in the guest profile indicates that the guest **16** has not been to this destination **120** ever, or for a long time, the reaction of the destination **120** may be more dramatic (e.g., windmill blades spin more rapidly) than if the guest profile indicates that the guest has been to the destination **120** recently. Alternatively, the reaction of the destination **120** may increase the more times the guest **16** has been within a certain proximity of the destination **120**, creating a crescendo in the reaction of the destination **120**. While the reaction has been discussed as being the blades of a windmill spinning, it should be understood that other reactions are included within the scope of the present disclosure, such as a water squirt, a fire blast, a sound or song, flashing lights, different colored lights, and the like.

(56) In addition to impacting the reactions of the destinations **120** as described above, the user information in the guest profile may also be used to help select the destination **120**. For example, if a guest **16** has a favorite premier ride, based on the user information counting the number of times that the guest **16** has visited such ride as informed by the guest profile, the interactive way-finder device **100** may display the title of the premier ride as the displayed destination **112** on the face **104** of the interactive way-finder device **100** when the guest **16** enters the amusement park **10**.

(57) In another embodiment, the interactive way-finder device **100** may react to inputs received (e.g., inputs received via data-over-sound). As used herein, data-over-sound technology means that ultrasound is used to transfer data between two devices by using a transmitter (e.g., a speaker) and an input source (e.g., a microphone). For data-over-sound technology, the data is encoded into an acoustic signal that is played into a space (for example, air, VoIP stream, wired telephone lines) and then received and demodulated by a listening device. Data is subsequently decoded by the listening device, or group of devices, and provides the original data to the listening device.

(58) For example, the device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100** may receive an ultrasound signal from an ultrasound transmitter, or speaker, inside the amusement park. The device communications circuitry **123** in the interactive way-finder device **100** may interact with the controller **118**, which may then activate onboard effects **128** of the interactive way-finder device **100**. The ultrasound signals may be generated in the amusement park, for example, and be encoded in certain songs, audio announcements, or other audio signals. In addition, the ultrasound signals may be received when the interactive way-finder device **100** is outside of the amusement park through broadcast music or announcements sponsored or otherwise affiliated with the amusement park. For example, the interactive way-finder device **100** may react while at a guest's home when an advertisement for the amusement park is broadcast within the guest's home. In this example, the device communications circuitry **123** of the interactive way-finder device **100** would receive the ultrasound signal embedded in the acoustic signal of the broadcast advertisement of the amusement park and the controller **118** may activate onboard effects **128** of the interactive way-finder device **100**, as described above.

(59) While only certain features of the invention have been illustrated and described herein, many modifications and changes will occur to those skilled in the art. It is, therefore, to be understood that the appended claims are intended to cover all such modifications and changes as fall within the true spirit of the disclosure.

(60) The techniques presented and claimed herein are referenced and applied to material objects

and concrete examples of a practical nature that demonstrably improve the present technical field and, as such, are not abstract, intangible or purely theoretical. Further, if any claims appended to the end of this specification contain one or more elements designated as “means for [perform]ing [a function] . . . ” or “step for [perform]ing [a function] . . . ”, it is intended that such elements are to be interpreted under 35 U.S.C. 112(f). However, for any claims containing elements designated in any other manner, it is intended that such elements are not to be interpreted under 35 U.S.C. 112(f).

Claims

1. An interactive way-finder system, comprising: a destination comprising an emitter; and an interactive way-finder device comprising: a housing; device communications circuitry disposed within the housing, the device communications circuitry configured to receive proximity information from the emitter, the proximity information comprising: an orientation of the interactive way-finder device relative to the emitter; and a distance between the interactive way-finder device and the emitter; a display coupled to the housing and comprising: a first hand and a second hand; and a displayed destination representative of the destination, wherein the interactive way-finder device is configured to change a position of the displayed destination on the display based on the proximity information from the emitter; and a processor configured to modify the display to change a distance between the first hand and the second hand based on the proximity information from the emitter, wherein the distance between the first hand and the second hand is representative of the distance between the interactive way-finder device and the emitter.
2. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the interactive way-finder device comprises an inertial measurement unit sensor and the processor is configured to cause the at least one of the first hand or the second hand to point in a direction of the destination based on information from the inertial measurement unit sensor.
3. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the displayed destination comprises a textual descriptor of the destination.
4. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the display is configured to change based on changes in the proximity information by moving the first hand and the second hand closer together in a radial direction in response to the proximity information indicating the interactive way-finder device is travelling in the direction of the destination and by moving the first hand and the second hand apart in the radial direction in response to the proximity information indicating the interactive way-finder is travelling in a direction different than that of the destination.
5. The interactive way-finder system of claim 4, wherein the first hand and the second hand are physical objects and are moved by a motor contained within the interactive way-finder device.
6. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the interactive way-finder device comprises onboard effects that are controlled by the processor and wherein the device communications circuitry is configured to activate one or more of the onboard effects based on communication with the emitter.
7. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the interactive way-finder device is associated with a user profile, and wherein user information is stored in the user profile and a central controller is configured to communicate the user information to memory in the interactive way-finder device via the device communications circuitry.
8. The interactive way-finder system of claim 7, wherein the user profile informs a selection of a displayed destination by the processor or a selection of one or more onboard effects by the processor.
9. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the processor is configured to select the destination from a plurality of destinations based on a relative location of the interactive way-finder system related to a nearest attraction or a nearest amenity.
10. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the destination comprises a sensor that

comprises destination communications circuitry and the device communications circuitry is configured to communicate with the destination communications circuitry to cause a reaction at the destination.

11. The interactive way-finder system of claim 10, wherein the reaction at the destination comprises emitting confetti, water spray, bubbles, or a combination thereof.

12. The interactive way-finder system of claim 10, wherein the interactive way-finder device is associated with a user profile, wherein user information is stored in the user profile and a central controller is configured to communicate the user profile to memory in the interactive way-finder device via the device communications circuitry, and wherein the reaction at the destination is informed by the user profile.

13. The interactive way-finder system of claim 1, wherein the display of the interactive way-finder device comprises a first face and a second face, wherein the first face has a first displayed destination of magnetic north.

14. An interactive way-finder device, comprising: a housing; memory disposed in the housing; device communications circuitry disposed within the housing, the device communications circuitry configured to: receive proximity information from an emitter associated with a destination, the proximity information comprising an orientation of the interactive way-finder device relative to the emitter and a first distance between the interactive way-finder device and the emitter; and store the proximity information in the memory; a display coupled to the housing and comprising a hand and a displayed destination representative of the destination, wherein the interactive way-finder device is configured to change a position of the displayed destination on the display based on the proximity information; an inertial measurement unit sensor disposed in the housing; a processor configured to: change a position of the hand based on inertial data from the inertial measurement unit sensor; modify the display to change a second distance between the hand and another hand of the display based at least in part on the proximity information, wherein the second distance is representative of the first distance; and cause the display to present the displayed destination representative of the destination.

15. The interactive way-finder device of claim 14, wherein the interactive way-finder device comprises one or more onboard effects configured to be activated by the processor based on the proximity information.

16. The interactive way-finder device of claim 14, wherein the displayed destination comprises a textual descriptor for the destination.

17. A method of way finding with an interactive way-finder device, the method comprising: receiving, via a processor, a first signal from an emitter comprising first proximity information for an attraction via wireless communications circuitry disposed in a housing of the interactive way-finder device, wherein the first proximity information comprises: a first distance between the interactive way-finder device and the attraction; and first orientation information indicative of a first orientation of the interactive way-finder device relative to the attraction; providing, via the processor, instructions to cause a display of the interactive way-finder device to display: a displayed destination representative of the attraction; and information related to the attraction based on the first proximity information, wherein the information related to the attraction comprises, at least in part, a space between a first hand and a second hand, wherein the space is representative of the first distance; receiving, via the processor, a second signal from the emitter comprising second proximity information for the attraction via the wireless communications circuitry, wherein the second proximity information comprises: a second distance between the interactive way-finder device and the attraction; and second orientation information indicative of a second orientation of the interactive way-finder device relative to the attraction; and providing, via the processor, updated instructions to modify the display of the interactive way-finder device to display updated information related to the attraction based on the second proximity information, wherein the updated information related to the attraction comprises, at least in part: a change in the space

between the first hand and the second hand such that the space is representative of the second distance; and a change in a position of the displayed destination on the display based on the second orientation information.

18. The method of claim 17, comprising: activating onboard effects of the interactive way-finder device based on the receiving of the first or second signal.

19. The method of claim 17, comprising: selecting a destination, wherein the destination comprises destination communications circuitry configured to send the second signal comprising the second proximity information via destination communications circuitry.

20. The method of claim 19, wherein selecting a destination is performed in response to receiving user input at the interactive way-finder device.
